

ANI

edented losses, with 207 cadres neutralised—the highest in Chhattisgarh's history. While the Union government's provision of resources and intelligence has been critical to this, Sai's tribal face has helped steer the state toward stability amidst the conflict.

The CM's welfare and governance initiatives apart, it's his performance on the political front that is being viewed keenly by observers. The BJP's dual deputy chief minister model, introduced to balance caste dynamics, created potential power centres in Vijay Sharma and Arun Sao. But recent developments suggest Sai—a former four-term Lok Sabha member and a Union minister of state who also held the state BJP's reins thrice—has consolidated authority. While Sharma, who has the home portfolio, initially took credit for Maoism-related successes, he has stopped making such statements of late. This silence hasn't gone unnoticed. Another potential rival, Brijmohan Agrawal, the seniormost leader to be inducted into Sai's cabinet, is not part of the government anymore after getting elected as Raipur MP. "There was an impression that there were multiple power centres within the government, but Vishnu Deo Sai and the party have managed to address this issue," notes Chhattisgarh-based senior journalist Sunil Kumar.

A cabinet expansion is also on the cards, likely aimed at reinforcing Sai's authority by inducting his loyalists. But his next big test are the impending civic body polls, for which Sai set the ball rolling by reverting to a system of direct elections for mayors and municipal presidents. The Congress, which had introduced indirect elections during its regime, is obviously not happy. "When the electoral system in India doesn't provide for direct elections for PM and CM, shouldn't we have indirect elections for mayors too?" asks state Congress spokesperson Sushil Anand Shukla. Sai's ability to balance economic growth with political and populist moves faces a defining moment. ■

WHAT'S DONE

- **Mahtari Vandan Yojana—a key pre-poll promise—is providing a monthly payout of Rs 1,000 to 7 million eligible women with an annual outflow of Rs 7,900 crore**
- **Input subsidies amounting to Rs 13,300 crore disbursed to almost 2.5 million paddy farmers. This ensured they got paid Rs 3,100 per quintal—about Rs 900 above the then MSP**
- **A tough stand against Maoism has led to the setting up of 30 additional security camps across Bastar. Net result: an unprecedented 207 of their cadres killed in 11 months**

WHAT'S NEXT

- **Plug leakages to significantly raise state's revenue without putting any tax burden on citizens—an imperative to generate funds for capital expenditure and offset outflow due to welfare schemes**
- **Ensure balanced regional development to improve education/ health indicators and raise incomes in tribal-dominated Surguja district in the north and Bastar in the south**

"To meet the fiscal challenge, we are trying to increase revenue inflow in excise and mining through reforms besides increasing GST collections"

VISHNU DEO SAI
Chief Minister, Chhattisgarh